

Chapter 67: Bracelet

At the same time, in the Eastern Wasteland¹, Chu Qingqiu, who was standing together with several other cultivators, weaving immortal power to repair the Eastern Wasteland Konghou², suddenly trembled. The qin³ string she had condensed with her immortal power immediately snapped.

The broken string rebounded with lightning speed, striking heavily against her wrist. Unable to dodge in time, Chu Qingqiu staggered backward repeatedly. The emerald bracelet on her wrist was knocked off and fell to the ground, the fragile common jade immediately shattering into four or five pieces with a crisp sound.

A flash of confusion crossed Chu Qingqiu's eyes. She instinctively bent to pick up the shattered bracelet. At the same time, a cultivator from the Great Vehicle Realm⁴ behind her quickly took her position, re-weaving the qin strings and replacing her.

"Divine Venerable!" Tang Wenshu nearby hurried forward to help her, but Chu Qingqiu instinctively avoided him. Embarrassment immediately appeared on his face, and he put his hands behind his back. "Is the Divine Venerable tired? I see that the Divine Venerable's immortal power is not as strong as before. This task of repairing the Eastern Wasteland Konghou is indeed mentally exhausting. I also had no choice but to summon all the immortal masters here. I truly trouble everyone."

The Eastern Wasteland had always been a place of exile for fallen immortals. Those immortals who had cultivated into demons and the monsters that were difficult to kill were all driven to this uninhabited territory, then suppressed by the divine instrument Eastern Wasteland Konghou's qin music. For millions of years, there had never been any trouble.

However, a few days ago, the Konghou suddenly broke several strings, causing many demons and fallen immortals to stir restlessly, breaking free from their restraints and disturbing the five realms. Tang Wenshu, the sect master of Tianji Sword Sect, had urgently sent letters to the six sects and other capable people to come together to the Eastern Wasteland to repair the Konghou.

"It's nothing." Chu Qingqiu stared blankly at the bracelet in her palm, feeling her heart panic terribly.

"The Divine Venerable's complexion doesn't seem very good," Tang Wenshu observed keenly.

"This venerable has urgent matters and must return to the sect." Chu Qingqiu's usually regular speech quickened. She gripped the jade bracelet tightly and put it in her sleeve. "I trouble Sect Master Tang to repair it for me."

Although Tang Wenshu was surprised, he quickly nodded: "Now that the Konghou is already half repaired, Divine Venerable may go attend to your business. Leave this place to us."

Having said this, he beckoned Elder Songxiang to see her off, but Chu Qingqiu shook her head to decline. Then she turned her palm, and the enlarged Bai Lin⁵ suddenly appeared in mid air.

Chu Qingqiu didn't even say many words of farewell. Her graceful body had already landed on Bai Lin's back, followed by a tiger's roar that shook the mountains and wilderness. A great wind swept by, and she had already disappeared beyond the Eastern Wasteland, becoming a tiny point of light.

Tang Wenshu and Elder Songxiang were blown about by the wind. While the few people repairing the Konghou concentrated on weaving immortal power into strings, they couldn't help but turn back and comment: "We've met with Divine Venerable Chu Ling several times. She has such a composed nature that she would remain calm even if lightning struck right in front of her. What could make her so anxious now?"

"Perhaps there's some disturbance at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate," Tang Wenshu said, removing the dead grass that had been blown onto his face by the wind. "Recently, for some unknown reason, demonic incidents have increased. The six major sects are almost all scattered throughout the martial world, yet there's still no peace."

"Not only is there no peace, even the long-silent demon realm has become restless, causing trouble everywhere. A conflict between immortals and demons is probably not far off!" said an old man who was holding his breath while repairing the qin strings, his face red. "This old man, a reclusive cultivator preparing to wait for death in the mountains, now has to come out to quell disturbances. But that so-called leader of the immortal realm, the Penglai Realm, where is even a bird's shadow to be seen!"

The other cultivators also complained upon hearing this. The Penglai Realm was originally the last divine bloodline, with divine blood flowing in their bodies, making them practically demi-gods. Therefore, their strength surpassed ordinary immortal cultivators, which was why they had always been called the leader of the immortal realm.

However, since a thousand years ago, the Penglai Realm seemed to have become isolated from the world.

"Alright, alright, everyone calm down. Repairing the Eastern Wasteland Konghou is important now. Don't disturb your state of mind, or if we release the demons, there will truly be chaos in the world!" Tang Wenshu quickly pacified them upon seeing this, and only then did everyone stop talking and concentrate again.

During the time they spoke, Chu Qingqiu had already left the Eastern Wasteland. She was still gripping that bracelet, commanding Bai Lin to return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate at the fastest speed.

She wouldn't panic for no reason, and the jade bracelet wouldn't shatter for no reason. She stood firmly on Bai Lin's spine, her fingertip sliding across the sharp fracture of the bracelet, cutting a bloody mark without even noticing.

The excessive speed brought up fierce winds that stirred her clothing all over. The thin fabric seemed about to be torn. The wind made her already weak body cold as ice, but Chu Qingqiu acted as if she felt nothing, not even using immortal power to warm herself.

Her peach blossom eyes were tightly closed, using the cold to control her mind, only hoping that everything was just her own wild imagination.

The journey that had taken half a day to come, Bai Lin forced to fly in only four hours. When Chu Qingqiu arrived at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, the sky was pitch black, the night sky covered by dense clouds. The black clouds stared at the human world like watchful beasts, brewing a storm.

She leaped down from mid-air, appearing directly in the Pearl Light Pavilion. The sleeping disciples immediately awakened, all opening their sleepy eyes to look outside the screen.

Chu Qingqiu ignored the others, reaching out to pull open the screen in front of Ning Fuyi's bed. Staring at the empty bed, her heart tightened, and then her figure disappeared again, causing several disciples to scream.

With a storm approaching, the entire mountain gate had closed all doors and windows. Only Cloud Deep Hall had dim lights burning. Chu Qingqiu swept her wide sleeves, and immortal power immediately burst open the hall doors, startling everyone inside.

Everyone was gathered here. Elder Pingyao's expression was cold and complex, Elder Yuanming also looked grave, his index finger unconsciously tapping on his folding fan. The Chief Elder was finally not dozing, opening a pair of turbid eyes and struggling to examine Chu Qingqiu.

In the shadows not far away hid another tall figure—it was the silent Mei Chengshu.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling?" Elder Jingshan, whose robes were even worn backwards, immediately became alert, his eyes bulging. "Didn't the Divine Venerable go to the Eastern Wasteland to repair the qin? How are you back at the gate so soon?"

"Where is Ning Fuyi?" Chu Qingqiu ignored him, her pale lips still carrying the cold air from outside.

As soon as her words fell, a figure came rushing forward and knelt down with a thump. Upon closer inspection, it was actually Rong Jin. His clothing still had dew on it, clearly showing he had also traveled a long way. He said anxiously: "Wenzhu was kidnapped by Li Zhao'an to Eastern Mountain. Fuyi went to save her and now there's no news. Please, Divine Venerable, save them both!"

After hearing his words clearly, Chu Qingqiu's cold body swayed for a moment, but she quickly steadied herself.

"Nonsense." A deliberately gentle voice suddenly came from the shadows. Mei Chengshu emerged with the sound, stepping into the lamplight. "Our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate has multiple protective barriers and is guarded by various elders. You just said this matter might be related to the demon clan—dare I ask what great ability this demon clan has to slip past the barriers and infiltrate the mountain gate without being detected by anyone!"

"Sect Master, this disciple speaks only the truth and dares not deceive!" Rong Jin said in a trembling voice.

"The Sect Master speaks reasonably. Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's barriers are the most solid, having had no incidents for many years. How could the demon clan break in? I think it's just a dispute or joke among sect disciples. Just send a few disciples to search for the three of them. There's no need to alarm the Divine Venerable and elders," Elder Jingshan also chimed in.

"Moreover, with chaos everywhere now, how can the gate be without people? If someone takes this opportunity to attack our mountain gate, wouldn't we fall into a strategy of luring the tiger away from the mountain?" Elder Jingshan added.

Seeing he couldn't convince them, Rong Jin was so anxious that sweat beaded on his forehead. He quickly turned and kowtowed before Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable, this disciple's words are not false. Fuyi said she saw strange traces with her own eyes. And even if this matter is unrelated to the demon clan, Wenzhu was taken by Li Zhao'an to who knows where. Please, Divine Venerable, intervene and save them!"

Although Ning Fuyi had asked him to wait for the Divine Venerable to return before telling her, with both junior sisters at Eastern Mountain with unknown conditions, he couldn't bear to wait. He tried to tell the other elders, asking them to help rescue the two.

However, he hadn't expected that even though this was a matter of life and death, no matter how much he talked until his lips were worn out, no one was willing to go to Eastern Mountain. They either doubted his words or felt this matter wasn't worth the trip.

These elders he had originally respected most had suddenly become strangers in his heart.

It was chilling.

"Please, Divine Venerable." Rong Jin pleaded again, slamming his forehead hard against the floor tiles, leaving a bloodstain.

Elder Pingyao closed her eyes slightly.

"Where are they?" Chu Qingqiu spoke. She quickly raised her hand to pull Rong Jin up from the ground and turned to stride over the threshold.

Just as Rong Jin was rejoicing, the door was suddenly engulfed by flames from both sides and slammed shut. If Chu Qingqiu hadn't been quick to step back, the door would have fallen right on her straight nose.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes harbored murderous intent as she slowly turned around to face the instigator of this fire: "What does Sect Master Mei mean by this?"

"Divine Venerable, please don't misunderstand." Mei Chengshu smiled. "This venerable is merely reminding the Divine Venerable not to rashly believe the words of a junior. These children don't understand the severity of matters. If we are led around by their noses without even seeing evidence, what rules will this mountain gate have in the future?"

"Elder Jingshan's words are not without reason. Since there are barriers protecting us, how could the demon clan enter the mountain? As for little Li Zhao'an, even if she really had a dispute with Liu Wenzhu, it's just children's games. Why would the Divine Venerable need to go personally?"

"Sect Master! You must not forget that Wenzhu is a daughter of the Liu family. If something happens to her, how will the Fragrant Mountain Liu family not..."

Rong Jin finally couldn't bear it anymore. The usually obedient young man began to speak harshly in defiance, but suddenly received a slap in mid-air, his handsome face jerking hard to one side.

He opened his eyes wide, unable to speak for a long moment.

"Sect Master Mei!" Elder Pingyao, who had been silent all along, finally couldn't suppress her anger when she saw her disciple being hit, shouting sternly, "Enough!"

"The demon clan can even infiltrate Zhaoyao Mountain⁶. Why couldn't they infiltrate our mere Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate?" the Chief Elder suddenly said tremblingly.

Elder Yuanming also stepped forward at this time, his folding fan snapping shut in his palm: "I also think, after all, this concerns our sect's disciples. If we still cling to old rigid rules, it would be too lacking in human feeling."

Chu Qingqiu remained silent, taking in all the chaos in the hall. However, worried about Ning Fuyi, she couldn't delay any longer and turned to forcibly leave. But the ground in front of her suddenly produced two puffs of smoke that transformed into two guardians, one left and one right, firmly blocking her path.

"What does Sect Master Mei mean by this?" Chu Qingqiu extended her slender hand to summon her white bone⁷. The cold aura around her immediately filled the great hall. "Are you so unwilling to let this venerable save disciples of our own sect?"

"I said, the gate cannot be without rules." Mei Chengshu seemed determined to stop Chu Qingqiu to establish his position as sect master. His face bore a smile as flames surged from his palms.

Usually, knowing he was no match for Chu Qingqiu, he wouldn't dare be so arrogant. But now this was...

Immortal power rose and fell within the hall, and just as internal strife was about to break out, another purple lightning suddenly lit up.

Accompanied by the sizzling sound of lightning, Mei Chengshu, who had somehow received a blow to the head, began convulsing all over. The flames in his palms had barely ignited before they were extinguished, and his tall, imposing figure crashed to the ground with a bang.

This revealed Elder Pingyao behind him, her face iron-blue, mouthing the word "idiot," with a meteor hammer in her palm.

Everyone was stunned, watching as she kicked aside the face-down Mei Chengshu and resumed her decisive manner: "Chief Elder and Elder Yuanming stay at the gate to protect the disciples. Elder Jingshan and I will follow the Divine Venerable to Eastern Mountain!"

"Rong Jin, quickly go to the Eastern Courtyard to find a few disciples still at the gate and set out with us. We leave in the time it takes to burn an incense stick."

"Quickly!" she said sternly. Rong Jin, who hadn't yet recovered, immediately scrambled up upon hearing this, turned and pushed aside the two guardians who no longer dared to move, and flew away on his sword.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips moved, and she put away her white bone and turned to enter the night.

The group stood upon Bai Lin, rushing toward Eastern Mountain through the fierce wind and rain. From the moment they left the gate, the previously stuffy sky completely broke open like a hole, pouring down torrential rain. Heaven and earth were completely covered by vast curtains of rain—nothing could be seen clearly, and flying through mid-air was like entering the sea.

It should have been dawn, yet the sky was still as black as midnight.

Bai Lin's body was wrapped in a layer of immortal power to block the rainwater. Chu Qingqiu stood at the front, facing the vast ocean where nothing could be seen. The wound on her fingertip that had been cut earlier was bleeding again from her grip.

It seemed that pain could somewhat lessen the anxiety in her heart.

The closer they got to Eastern Mountain, the more afraid she became. She had seemed to be this afraid before, but that time had been even more heart-wrenching.

Now, however, she felt like being thrown into a pot of warm water, slowly being cooked.

"Eastern Mountain is here!" Feng Ge behind her suddenly said. She looked down through the rain curtain and could only see a blurry stretch of mountain forest.

Rong Jin also searched desperately, finally finding the swamp where Ning Fuyi was located based on memory, pointing below: "Divine Venerable, Elder, it's right here!"

Elder Pingyao closed her eyes to search with her divine consciousness, then suddenly remembered something. Her heart shook, and she opened her eyes: "No good, this place is a tiger's den!"

As soon as she finished speaking, Bai Lin suddenly dove downward, causing everyone to tumble about, gripping the tiger fur tightly to avoid being thrown off.

Bai Lin quickly descended close to the ground. Before landing, Chu Qingqiu's figure had already leaped out, falling into the swamp in the rain. She immediately saw a huge stone tablet with red characters, and beneath the tablet lay a person, already half-submerged in water.

Rainwater flowed down her hair into her clothing, but Chu Qingqiu seemed unaware. She didn't even notice that her hands were constantly trembling. She flashed to the side of that figure and reached out to pull her up.

The moment she saw that face clearly, Chu Qingqiu nearly fell into the muddy water with her.

That person's face was deathly pale, her body frail—clearly Liu Wenzhu. She was just waking up at this moment, staring blankly at the rainy night sky above, then clearly saw Chu Qingqiu's face.

"Divine Venerable!" She desperately grabbed Chu Qingqiu, bursting into tears. "Divine Venerable, Ning Fuyi, Ning Fuyi she..."

"Jumped into the bronze furnace and turned to ash!"

Footnotes:

¹ Eastern Wasteland (东荒) - A desolate region used as a place of exile for fallen immortals and demons

² Konghou (箜篌) - An ancient Chinese harp-like stringed instrument; here it's a divine artifact used for suppression

³ Qin (琴) - A seven-stringed Chinese musical instrument, often translated as guqin

⁴ Great Vehicle Realm (大乘) - One of the cultivation realms established in the story's power system

⁵ Bai Lin (白麟) - Chu Qingqiu's white qilin mount

⁶ Zhaoyao Mountain (招摇山) - Another sect's mountain that was previously mentioned as being infiltrated

⁷ White bone - Chu Qingqiu's signature weapon, likely made of white bone or ivory